

Dvar Torah Outline — Rosh Chodesh Menachem Av: Hidden Light in the Nine Days, “Moed,” and Teshuvah Me’Ahavah

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman explores the inner paradox of the Nine Days: while the lived experience is mourning and darkness, Chazal reveal an underlying dimension of **moed** (festive sanctity) embedded specifically in Rosh Chodesh Av and even Tishah B’Av. Drawing on the Pri Tzaddik, Sefer Yetzirah, and sugyot about Hallel on Rosh Chodesh, Rabbi Shulman explains how **the month of Av is linked to the letter v**—the hidden goodness of the concealed light. He then connects this to the transformative power of **teshuvah me’ahavah**, in which the very darkness of churban becomes retroactively reframed as fuel for return and rebuilding.

I. Framing: the “revealed” Nine Days vs. the deeper story in Chazal

- Rabbi Shulman opens on **Rosh Chodesh Menachem Av**, standing at the beginning of the Nine Days.
- Contrast:
 - The **experienced** Nine Days feel like mourning, distance, and darkness.
 - But the **Torah/Chazal lens** reveals a deeper layer that can intensify authentic mourning if the Beit HaMikdash is not rebuilt by Tishah B’Av.
- Goal: uncover depth that leads to more truthful avodah—mourning that is not superficial.

A. Source focus

- Rabbi Shulman learns a piece from **Rabbi Tzadok HaKohen (Pri Tzaddik)** on Rosh Chodesh Menachem Av.
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II. “קרא עלי מועד”: how Rosh Chodesh (and Tishah B’Av) are called a moed (1:30)

A. Gemara Pesachim: Rosh Chodesh as “moed”

- Rabbi Shulman cites a Gemara (Pesachim): Where do we see **Rosh Chodesh** has a status of **moed**?
- It derives this from a verse in Eichah:
 - “קרא עלי מועד” (He proclaimed a moed against me / He called an appointed time upon me.)

B. Peshat vs. drash

- Peshat: enemies “call a gathering” to afflict and destroy.
- Drash: the word **מועד** also means a **festival/holy appointed time**, implying an inner “moed-status” even within calamity.

C. Halachic/nusach payoff: no Tachanun on Tishah B’Av

- Rabbi Shulman highlights the irony:
 - On Tishah B’Av we do not say **Tachanun**—because it is called a **moed**.
 - This is “unexpected” amid the tears of the day.

D. Rosh Chodesh Av as the “source-model” for other Roshei Chodashim

- Rabbi Shulman explains that **Rosh Chodesh Menachem Av** becomes a kind of **בנין אב**:
 - from it we learn the broader principle that **Rosh Chodesh** carries a moed-quality.

III. “השוכן איתם בתוך טומאותם” and “במועדו”: the korban of Rosh Chodesh even in tumah (4:30)

A. The Rosh Chodesh se’ir and communal tumah

- Rabbi Shulman notes a sugya: the **Rosh Chodesh goat-offering** can be brought even when the majority of the nation is **tamei** (tumah b’tzibbur considerations).
- The reason: it must be brought “**במועדו**”—in its appointed time.

B. Moed as Hashem's meeting/revelation

- Rabbi Shulman ties “moed” to Hashem’s revelation in the Mikdash:
 - “אֲשֶׁר אֶנְעֵד לָכֶם שָׁמָּה” (...where I will meet with you there.)
- And to Hashem’s presence even amid impurity:
 - “הַשֹּׁכֵן אִתָּם בְּתוֹךְ טִמְאַתָּם” (Who dwells with them in the midst of their impurities.)

C. Conceptual synthesis

- When Israel gathers as a **moed**, Hashem is “with us” even in **tumah**—even in a state of distance and disconnection.
 - Rabbi Shulman applies this to the emotional/spiritual state of Av: a month of mourning that still contains a mode of divine presence.
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IV. Why Chazal call Rosh Chodesh a “mikra kodesh” despite the Torah not using that phrase (7:30)

A. Observation: the Torah doesn’t label Rosh Chodesh “מקרא קודש”

- Rabbi Shulman notes:
 - In davening we refer to Rosh Chodesh as **מקרא קודש**.
 - But the Torah’s pesukim do not explicitly apply that term to Rosh Chodesh.

B. Mishnah Rosh Hashanah: “מקודש מקודש”

- The Beit Din sanctifies the new moon and the people respond:
 - “מְקֻדָּשׁ! מְקֻדָּשׁ!” (Sanctified! Sanctified!)
- Rabbi Shulman’s inference:
 - If Chazal coin a term the Torah didn’t use, they are revealing a **hidden depth**—a sanctity not plainly visible.

C. Challenge posed

- Rabbi Shulman frames it as an interpretive challenge:
 - What is this “hidden kedushah” of Rosh Chodesh that Chazal are uncovering?
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V. Sefer Yetzirah: Av, the letter ט, and the “hidden good” of light (9:30)

A. Sefer Yetzirah as a lens on the months

- Rabbi Shulman references **Sefer Yetzirah** (attributed to Avraham Avinu; later associated with early transmission/compilation).
- It connects each month to letters and spiritual anatomy.

B. Av corresponds to the letter ט

- Rabbi Shulman notes:
 - Av is linked to ט (gematria 9), suggestive of **תשעה באב**.

C. Gemara Bava Kamma: seeing ט in a dream is a good sign

- Reason: first appearance of ט in the Torah is in **טוב**:
 - “**וַיַּרְא אֱלֹהִים אֶת הָאֹר כִּי טוֹב**” (Hashem saw the light, that it was good.)

D. The paradox: Av as “good light” despite the churban

- Rabbi Shulman emphasizes the irony:
 - Both Batei Mikdash were destroyed in Av, and the Mikdash is called “light.”

E. Herod and “the light of the world”

- Rabbi Shulman brings a Gemara (Bava Batra) describing Herod:
 - After harming Torah leadership, he is told to “restore the light of the world” by rebuilding/renovating the Mikdash.
- Point: the Mikdash is identified as a **light-source**.

F. The “אור הגנוז”: goodness hidden as darkness

- Rabbi Shulman ties טוב/ט to the first-day light that was hidden:
 - Rashi: Hashem hid the light away for the righteous **לעתיד לבוא**.
 - In this world, the truest light can appear as concealment:
 - “Darkness” can be the **outer form** of a concealed אור.
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VI. Why Hallel on Rosh Chodesh is “half”: the minhag of Bavel and learning to find light in exile (16:32)

A. Gemara Arachin: why not full Hallel on Rosh Chodesh?

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - Rosh Chodesh lacks מלאכה-prohibitions like a full Yom Tov.
 - Therefore Hallel is not mandated like on the Regalim; we say **half Hallel**.

B. Story in Gemara Ta'anit: Rav in Bavel

- Rav arrives in Bavel and sees people saying Hallel on Rosh Chodesh.
- He initially wants to protest—until he sees they skip sections, realizing it is **minhag**, not full obligation.
- He concludes:
 - “שָׁמַע מִיָּנָה מִנְהַג אֲבוֹתֵיהֶם בְּיָדֵיהֶם” (From here we learn: the custom of their fathers is in their hands.)

C. Why specifically Bavel developed this minhag

- Rabbi Shulman's explanation:
 - Bavel is a community founded on **churban**—living without the Mikdash.
 - Chazal associate Bavel with darkness (from Eichah):
 - “בְּמַחְשָׁכִים הוֹשִׁיבָנִי” (He has made me dwell in dark places.)
 - Gemara: **זו בבל** (this refers to Bavel).
- In the dark, people learn to detect and value even a small point of light:
 - hence recognizing a “spark” of Yom Tov in Rosh Chodesh through **half Hallel**.

D. Minhagim reflecting “Rosh Chodesh kedushah”

- Rabbi Shulman mentions related expressions:
 - Some have minhagim limiting certain forms of מלאכה on Rosh Chodesh (especially among women).
 - There is a notion of a festive meal (e.g., Shaul HaMelech's Rosh Chodesh seudah; David's absence is consequential).

E. Prophetic-era origins (as suggested in discussion)

- Rabbi Shulman suggests the minhag may trace back as far as the time of the early return from Bavel (when prophets still existed), indicating how early Jews in exile “reinvented” spiritual life.
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VII. Tishah B’Av as “hidden tov”: darkness that awakens teshuvah (28:30)

A. From churban to hirhurei teshuvah

- Rabbi Shulman cites Midrash Eichah:
 - immediately after witnessing churban, the people experienced **hirhurei teshuvah**—the beginnings of inner return.
- Principle: only from darkness can one properly recognize what light was.

B. “Rock bottom” as the beginning of turning

- Rabbi Shulman uses an analogy:
 - like addiction recovery—change often starts only after “hitting rock bottom.”
 - Applied to Tishah B’Av:
 - the encounter with devastation is what starts the climb.
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VIII. Teshuvah that rewrites the past: “גדולה תשובה (31:30) and teshuvah me’ahavah (31:30) תשובה”

A. Gemara: teshuvah “pushes aside” a Torah prohibition

- Rabbi Shulman brings the teaching:
 - “גְּדוּלָהּ תְּשׁוּבָה שְׂדוּקָה לֹא תַעֲשֶׂה שְׂבִיתוֹרָה” (Great is teshuvah, for it pushes aside a negative commandment in the Torah.)
- Example given: the prohibition of remarrying one’s ex-wife after she was with another man.

B. The question: does Hashem “break His own rules”?

- Rabbi Shulman develops the challenge:
 - Hashem “divorced” Israel (metaphorically) yet calls for return—how is that possible?

C. Rav Tatz (as cited): teshuvah can make it “as if it never happened”

- Rabbi Shulman quotes Rav Tatz’s framing:
 - teshuvah’s power is not merely forgiveness; it can transform reality such that the wrongdoing is retroactively undone in meaning.

D. The Izhbitzer: “ממרים הייתם עם ה'” — rebellion “with” Hashem (35:00)

- Rabbi Shulman cites the Izhbitzer’s reading of:
 - “מְמָרִים הָיִיתֶם עִם ה'” (You were rebellious with Hashem.)
- Why “with” and not “against”?
 - In the deepest frame, after **teshuvah me’ahavah**, one recognizes that even failures were ultimately folded into Hashem’s plan to propel a person closer.

E. Free will and divine foreknowledge—resolved only post-teshuvah me’ahavah

- Rabbi Shulman (in the name of Rabbi Tzadok) sketches the paradox:
 - before an act: genuine free will;
 - after the fact: accepting Hashem’s knowledge/decreed is dangerous unless it leads to real repentance.
 - Safeguard:
 - only **teshuvah me’ahavah** converts sins into merits; otherwise the act remains an עבירה.
 - **teshuvah mi’yirah** may remove punishment but does not transform the act into זכות.
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IX. Applying it to our generation: churban continues because the causes continue (42:30)

A. Why Tishah B’Av is not only history

- Rabbi Shulman insists the churban is ongoing in a real sense:
 - If the Mikdash is not rebuilt, it indicates persistent spiritual blockage.

B. “Any generation not rebuilt—as if destroyed in its days”

- Rabbi Shulman cites Chazal:
 - any generation in which the Mikdash is not rebuilt is considered as though it was destroyed then.

C. Sins named: Sinat chinam and beyond

- Rabbi Shulman reviews the traditional causes:
 - Second Mikdash: **שנאת חינוך**
 - First Mikdash: also described via severe sins; additionally framed as deterioration rooted in lack of proper relationship to Torah (e.g., *שלא בירכו בתורה תחילה* as explained by Maharal).
 - Point: these patterns remain present; therefore the absence of rebuilding is spiritually intelligible.
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X. The avodah of the Nine Days: not fleeing darkness, but embracing it as the seed of light (45:11)

A. Tishah B’Av: the job is to feel the darkness

- Rabbi Shulman clarifies:
 - On Tishah B’Av itself, the avodah is not to “run” to consolation, but to experience desolation honestly.

B. Darkness contains the light that powers teshuvah

- The experience becomes the catalyst:
 - it awakens the heart the next day to begin teshuvah.
- If that teshuvah becomes **me’ahavah**, then **retroactively** the darkness is revealed as hidden light.

C. Closing image: the moon as hidden light emerging

- Rabbi Shulman returns to Rosh Chodesh symbolism:
 - the moon appears absent, yet its light was “there,” merely concealed.
 - The Nine Days intensify toward deeper darkness; embracing that reality is itself the path toward redemption and rebuilding.
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In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman shows that **Rosh Chodesh Av** is the paradigm for Rosh Chodesh as **moed**, sourced in **”קרא עלי מועד.”**
- A **moed** means Hashem “meets” Israel even **within tumah**—divine presence persists even amid distance.
- **Av = טוב = ט**, pointing to the **אור הגנוז**: light so holy it appears as concealment—especially within churban.
- The minhag of **half Hallel on Rosh Chodesh** (especially rooted in **Bavel**) expresses learning to find sparks of light in exile.
- The deepest reframing comes through **teshuvah me’ahavah**, which can transform darkness into the very fuel of ascent—until the hidden light is ultimately revealed in redemption.